PADHAKU
Democratic Politics · Class 10 Social Science



CHAPTER 5

Outcomes of Democracy

NCERT Exercise Solutions

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✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

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🤔 Think · How do we assess democracy's outcomes?

? **Did we reach these conclusions in Madam Lyngdoh's class? I loved that class because students were not being dictated any conclusions.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Yes. In Class IX the students discussed freely and themselves concluded that democracy is better than other forms of government because it:

- promotes **equality** among citizens;
- enhances the **dignity** of the individual;
- improves the **quality of decision-making**;
- provides a method to **resolve conflicts**; and
- allows room to **correct mistakes**.

No one forced these conclusions on them – this itself is a democratic way of learning.

Cartoon **Is democracy all about coping with multiple pressures and accommodating diverse demands?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Largely yes, but not only that.

- A democratic government must listen to many groups with different, often opposite demands, and find a balance through **deliberation and negotiation**.

- This is why it seems slow and can never satisfy everyone fully.
- But democracy is also about **accountability, legitimacy, equality, dignity and freedom** of citizens.

So handling diverse demands is an important part of democracy, but not the whole of it.

🤔 Think · Accountable, responsive and legitimate government

? Can you think of what and how the government knows about you and your family (for example ration cards and voter identity cards)? What are the sources of information for you about the government?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

What the government knows about us: name, age, address, family members, income group (ration card), voter details (voter ID card), Aadhaar number and biometric data, PAN/tax details, school records, bank account and land records.

It collects this through forms we fill, the census, surveys, registration of births and deaths, and applications for cards and schemes.

Our sources of information about the government:

- Newspapers, TV, radio and news websites
- Government websites, apps and notices

- Debates in Parliament and Assemblies
- Applications under the **Right to Information (RTI) Act**
- Public meetings, gram sabha, political parties and elected representatives

? So, the best outcome of democracy is that it is a democracy! That is what we have discovered after all this mental gymnastics?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

In a way, yes. Democracy may be slow, not always responsive or free of corruption.

- But a democratic government is **legitimate** – it is the **people's own government**, chosen by them.
- That is why there is overwhelming support for democracy all over the world, even in countries without democratic regimes (for example, the South Asia survey).

Democracy's ability to generate its own support is itself an outcome that cannot be ignored.

🤔 Think · Economic growth and development

? Should the gains of economic growth be evenly distributed? How can the poor get a voice for a better share in a nation? What can

the poor countries do to receive a greater share in the world's wealth?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Even distribution: Yes, gains of growth should reach all fairly. Growth that makes only a few richer increases inequality and is not real development.

Voice for the poor in a nation:

- Use their **vote** wisely; the poor are a large part of voters.
- Form **organisations, unions and movements** to raise demands.
- Use rights such as **RTI**, approach courts and the media.

Poor countries in the world:

- Unite and **bargain together** in international bodies (e.g. WTO, UN).
- Demand fair trade rules and access to technology.
- Invest in education, health and their own industries to become self-reliant.

⭐ Economic outcomes of democracy

? **What would be your verdict on democracy if you had to base it purely on economic performance of democratic regimes in terms of growth and equal distribution?**

Table 1 (growth rate 1950–2000): All democratic regimes 3.95; All dictatorial

regimes 4.42; Poor countries under dictatorship 4.34; Poor countries under democracy 4.28.

Table 2 (share of national income, Top 20% / Bottom 20%): South Africa 64.8 / 2.9; Brazil 63.0 / 2.6; Russia 53.7 / 4.4; USA 50.0 / 4.0; UK 45.0 / 6.0; Denmark 34.5 / 9.6; Hungary 34.4 / 10.0.

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Judged only on economics, the verdict on democracy would be **average or mixed**:

- **Growth:** Dictatorships grew slightly faster on average (4.42 against 3.95). But among **poor countries** the difference is negligible (4.34 against 4.28).
- **Equal distribution:** Democracies have not removed inequality. In South Africa and Brazil the top 20% take over 60% of income, the bottom 20% less than 3%. Denmark and Hungary are much better.
- The poor often lack equal opportunities, as the cartoon shows.

So democracy is **not a guarantee** of economic development or equality, but it does **not lag far behind** dictatorships. Since democracy has many other positive outcomes (dignity, freedom, legitimacy), it should still be preferred.

🤔 Think · Reduction of inequality and poverty

? Democracy is a rule of the majority. The poor are in majority. So democracy must be a rule of the poor. How can this not be the case?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

In theory the poor, being the majority, should decide policies. In practice this does not happen because:

- The poor are **divided** by caste, religion, region and language, so they do not vote as one group.
- The **rich and powerful** control money, media and parties, and influence elections and policies.
- Many poor people lack education, information and time to take part actively.
- Parties make promises to the poor but often do not act on them after elections.

So democratic governments are not as keen to remove poverty as we would expect.

🤔 Think · Accommodation of social diversity

? All you are saying is that democracy ensures that people do not break each other's head. This is not harmony. Should we be happy about it?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Yes, it is an important achievement, though not complete harmony.

- No society can fully and permanently resolve conflicts among groups.
- Democracy develops **procedures** for groups to compete peacefully, so tensions do not become explosive or violent.
- It teaches people to **respect differences** and creates mechanisms to **negotiate** them (e.g. Belgium).
- Non-democratic regimes often suppress or ignore social differences, which can explode later.

So peaceful handling of conflict is a **definite plus point** of democracy; real harmony can be built on it over time.

Activity **The two images ("Enemies" and "Greeting") depict two different kinds of effects democratic politics can have on social divisions. Take one example for each image and write a paragraph each on the outcome of democratic politics in both situations.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Enemies – democracy can deepen divisions: In **Sri Lanka**, the Sinhala majority used democratic power to impose Sinhala as the only official language and favour Sinhala speakers in jobs and education. The Tamils felt alienated, their demands were ignored, and distrust turned into a long civil war. Here majority rule became rule by the majority community, and democratic politics made the groups enemies.

Greeting – democracy can bring groups together: In **Belgium**, the Dutch- and French-speaking communities agreed to share power: equal ministers in the central government, powers to state and community governments, and a separate government for Brussels. Each group felt respected, tensions were reduced and the country stayed united. Here democratic politics helped people accept each other and live in peace.

(check the pictures in your book)

🧪 Activity · Dignity and freedom of the citizens

Activity **The cartoon ("Rosa Parks Still Inspires") and graph (Those who say that their vote makes a difference: South Asia 65, Bangladesh 66, India 67, Nepal 75, Pakistan 50, Sri Lanka 65) illustrate a point made in the section "Dignity and freedom of the citizens". Underline the**

sentences from this section which connect to the cartoon or graph.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Sentences connected to the cartoon (Rosa Parks – struggle for equal respect):

- "Democracy stands much superior to any other form of government in promoting dignity and freedom of the individual."
- "Every individual wants to receive respect from fellow beings."
- "The passion for respect and freedom are the basis of democracy."
- "Once the principle is recognised, it becomes easier for women to wage a struggle against what is now unacceptable legally and morally."
- "Democracy in India has strengthened the claims of the disadvantaged and discriminated castes for equal status and equal opportunity."

Sentences connected to the graph (belief in the vote):

- "It transforms people from the status of a subject into that of a citizen."
- "Most individuals today believe that their vote makes a difference to the way the government is run and to their own self-interest."

Exercises

1 **How does democracy produce an accountable, responsive and legitimate government?**

✔ ANSWER

Accountable: People choose their rulers through **regular, free and fair elections** and can remove them if they do not perform. Decisions follow norms and procedures, and citizens can check them – this is **transparency** (e.g. Right to Information).

Responsive: An elected government has to attend to the **needs and expectations** of the people to win the next election. Open public debate on major policies and laws, a free media and opposition parties keep it alert.

Legitimate: A democratic government may be slow or less efficient, but it is the **people's own government**, elected by them. That is why there is overwhelming support for democracy all over the world.

Thus democracy produces a government that is answerable to the people and accepted by them.

2 **What are the conditions under which democracies accommodate social diversities?**

✔ ANSWER

Democracy accommodates social diversity when two conditions are fulfilled:

- **Democracy is not simply rule by majority opinion.** The majority must always work with the minority so that the government represents the general view. Majority and minority opinions are not permanent.
- **Rule by majority must not become rule by the majority community** in terms of religion, race or language. In every decision or election, different persons and groups may form a majority.

Democracy remains democracy only as long as **every citizen has a chance of being in majority** at some point of time. If someone is barred from the majority on the basis of birth, democracy stops being accommodative for that person or group (e.g. Sri Lanka).

3 (a) **Give arguments to support or oppose: Industrialised countries can afford democracy but the poor need dictatorship to become rich.**

✔ ANSWER

Oppose.

- Between 1950 and 2000, poor countries under dictatorship grew at 4.34% and those under democracy at 4.28% – the difference is **negligible**.
- Economic growth depends on many factors: population size, global situation, cooperation from other countries and economic priorities, not only on the type of government.
- Dictatorship does not guarantee that wealth will reach the poor; it denies them freedom, dignity and a voice.
- Democracy gives the poor the right to vote and to demand a share in growth.

So poor countries do not need dictatorship to become rich.

3 (b) **Give arguments to support or oppose: Democracy can't reduce inequality of incomes between different citizens.**

✔ ANSWER

Partly support, but oppose the idea that it can't.

- **Support:** In practice democracies have not been very successful in reducing inequality. In South Africa and Brazil the top 20% take over 60% of national income and the bottom 20% less than 3%.
- **Oppose:** Democracies like **Denmark and Hungary** have much lower inequality (top 20% about 34%, bottom 20% about 10%).

- Democracy gives political equality – one person, one vote – so the poor can elect governments that adopt welfare policies, taxes on the rich, reservations and poverty-removal schemes.

So democracy **can** reduce inequality if citizens use their power; it does not happen automatically.

3 (c) **Give arguments to support or oppose: Government in poor countries should spend less on poverty reduction, health, education and spend more on industries and infrastructure.**

✔ ANSWER

Oppose.

- Poverty reduction, health and education build **human capital**; healthy and educated people work better and help industries grow.
- In a democracy the government must be **responsive** to the needs of the people, and the poor are a large part of the population.
- Growth from industries alone may increase inequality, leaving the poor unable to meet basic needs.
- Industries and infrastructure are also needed, so a **balance** is best: both should get funds.

So cutting spending on the poor, health and education would be wrong.

3 (d) **Give arguments to support or oppose: In democracy all citizens have one vote, which means that there is absence of any domination and conflict.**

✔ ANSWER

Oppose.

- One person, one vote gives **political equality**, but economic and social inequalities remain.
- A small number of ultra-rich have a large share of wealth and influence over politics.
- Domination based on caste, gender and religion still exists (e.g. atrocities against dalits, unequal treatment of women), though it lacks legal and moral support.
- Conflicts among social groups continue; democracy only provides peaceful ways to **negotiate** them.

So equal voting rights do not mean the absence of domination and conflict.

4 (a) **Identify the challenge to democracy and suggest policy/institutional mechanism to deepen democracy: Following a High Court directive, a temple in Orissa that had separate entry doors for dalits and non-**

dalits allowed entry for all from the same door.

✔ ANSWER

Challenge: Caste discrimination and untouchability – the challenge of ensuring **equality and dignity** for all citizens (challenge of deepening democracy).

Mechanisms:

- Strict enforcement of laws against untouchability (Article 17) and atrocities on SCs.
- An independent **judiciary** that protects fundamental rights, as the High Court did here.
- Awareness campaigns, education and social reform so that people change their attitudes.
- Strengthening bodies like the National Commission for Scheduled Castes.

4 (b) **Identify the challenge to democracy and suggest policy/institutional mechanism: A large number of farmers are committing suicide in different states of India.**

✔ ANSWER

Challenge: Economic distress and poverty of farmers – democracy has not ensured **economic well-being and reduction of inequality** for all; the government is not fully responsive to their needs.

Mechanisms:

- Easy and cheap loans from banks and cooperatives; protection from moneylenders.
- Fair prices for crops (minimum support price) and crop insurance.
- Better irrigation, seeds and modern farming methods.
- Farmers' organisations and panchayats to raise their voice; quick relief and debt counselling.

4 (c) **Identify the challenge to democracy and suggest policy/institutional mechanism: Following an allegation of killing of three civilians in Gandwara in a fake encounter by Jammu and Kashmir police, an enquiry has been ordered.**

✔ ANSWER

Challenge: Violation of **human rights** and the right to life by the police – the challenge of making government agencies **accountable** and protecting the dignity and freedom of citizens.

Mechanisms:

- Fair, independent and time-bound enquiries; punishment of guilty officials.
- Strong human rights commissions (NHRC, State HRCs) and courts.
- Police reforms, training in human rights, and transparency in police action.

- A free media and civil society to bring such cases to light.

5 **In the context of democracies, which of the following ideas is correct – democracies have successfully eliminated: A. conflicts among people B. economic inequalities among people C. differences of opinion about how marginalised sections are to be treated D. the idea of political inequality**

✔ ANSWER

D. the idea of political inequality

Democracy gives every citizen one vote of equal value; conflicts, economic inequalities and differences of opinion still exist.

6 **In the context of assessing democracy, which among the following is the odd one out. Democracies need to ensure: A. free and fair elections B. dignity of the individual C. majority rule D. equal treatment before law**

✔ ANSWER

C. majority rule

Democracy is not simply rule by majority; the majority must work with the minority. The other three are basic guarantees democracy must give to all.

7 **Studies on political and social inequalities in democracy show that: A. democracy and development go together. B. inequalities exist in democracies. C. inequalities do not exist under dictatorship. D. dictatorship is better than democracy.**

✔ ANSWER

B. inequalities exist in democracies.

Table 2 shows very high inequality in democracies like South Africa and Brazil.

8 **Nannu, a daily wage earner in a slum in East Delhi, lost his ration card and applied for a duplicate in January 2004. For three months the officials ignored him. He then filed an application under the Right to Information Act asking for the daily progress on his application, names of the officials responsible and the action against them for inaction. Within a week an inspector told him the card was ready; the Food and Supply Officer gave him a warm welcome, offered tea and requested him to withdraw his RTI application.**

What does Nannu's example show? What impact did Nannu's action have on officials? Ask your parents their experiences when they approach government officials to attend to their problems.

✔ ANSWER

What it shows:

- Democracy gives even a poor citizen the **right and the means** to hold the government accountable.
- The **Right to Information Act** is a powerful tool for **transparency**; it makes officials answerable to citizens.
- When citizens use their rights, democracy works better.

Impact on officials:

- They became afraid of being exposed and punished for inaction, so they did his work within a week.
- Their behaviour changed from ignoring him to treating him with respect; they even asked him to withdraw the application.

Parents' experiences (sample): Earlier, getting a ration card or certificate meant many visits and long waits. Now online applications, helplines and RTI have made it easier and faster, though delays still happen in some offices.

🎉 **Chapter 5 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**